



Smart Local Bus Route Finder

A Database-Driven Analytical Dashboard for Karachi's Public Bus Network

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Live: <https://smart-bus-route-finder.vercel.app>

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This project was completed as a group effort by Abdul Rafay (2412182) and Varun Sainani (2412222). Both members contributed to the database design, backend development, frontend dashboard, testing, and documentation.

Table of Contents

Section	Title
1	Title Page
2	Acknowledgement
3	Table of Contents
4	List of Tables
5	List of Figures
6	Introduction
7	Problem Statement
8	Proposed Solution
9	Entity Relationship Diagram (ERD)
10	Class Diagram
11	Software Specifications
12	Database Design and Implementation
13	API Development (Endpoints, Methods, Testing Results)
14	Screenshots of API Methods
15	JavaScript Code Showing API Calls
16	Dashboard Design and Implementation
17	Final Output Screenshots
18	Conclusion
19	References

List of Tables

The database contains 21 tables, grouped into three functional areas.

No.	Table	Purpose
1	zone	Geographic and fare zones of Karachi
2	operator	Bus operators running services in the city
3	route_type	Service category (BRT, Feeder, Electric, Intercity)
4	route	A named bus service
5	stop	A physical bus stop or BRT station
6	route_stop	Ordered stops on a route (the graph edges)
7	fare_stage	Distance band fare rules per route type
8	bus_model	Vehicle model specification
9	bus	A physical fleet vehicle
10	driver	Drivers employed by operators
11	staff	Station based staff
12	schedule	Scheduled trips on a route
13	trip_log	Completed trips (operational analytics)
14	maintenance	Vehicle maintenance records
15	passenger	Registered app users / commuters
16	fare_card	Stored value transit cards
17	card_transaction	Top ups, refunds and fare deductions
18	journey	Actual passenger journeys (main fact table)
19	route_search	Logged in-app route lookups
20	feedback	Passenger ratings and complaints
21	incident	Service incidents and disruptions

List of Figures

Figure	Description
Figure 1	Entity Relationship Diagram (21 entities)
Figure 2	Class Diagram (layered application architecture)
Figure 3	API Testing Console - GET endpoint results
Figure 4	API Testing Console - CRUD round trip (POST, GET, PUT, DELETE)
Figure 5	Analytical Dashboard - route finder and KPI cards
Figure 6	Analytical Dashboard - full page with all charts
Figure 7	Route Finder - journey plan with transfer on the map
Figure 8	Responsive (mobile) view of the dashboard

6. Introduction

Public transportation in Karachi is used by millions of commuters every day. In recent years the city has introduced a structured Bus Rapid Transit (BRT) network, including the Green Line and Red Line corridors, along with the Peoples Bus Service feeder routes and a fleet of electric buses. Despite this progress, there is no single digital system that helps a passenger decide which bus to take, where to change buses, how much the journey will cost, and how long it will take.

The Smart Local Bus Route Finder is a database-driven analytical dashboard and route planning system built for this scenario. It is composed of a PostgreSQL database hosted on Neon, a REST API built with Node.js and Express, and an analytical dashboard built with HTML, CSS, Bootstrap, and JavaScript. The dashboard presents meaningful insights generated from the database, such as ridership, revenue, on-time performance, and popular destinations, while an integrated route finder computes the cheapest journey across the bus network using a shortest-path algorithm.

This report documents the complete project: the problem it addresses, the proposed solution, the database design, the API, and the analytical dashboard, along with testing results and output screenshots. The project satisfies the Database Systems final project requirements, including a relational schema of more than sixteen tables and a working analytical dashboard.

The complete system is deployed and publicly accessible at <https://smart-bus-route-finder.vercel.app>. The source code is available at <https://github.com/varunsainani/smart-bus-route-finder>.

7. Problem Statement

Existing Challenges

New passengers and even regular commuters in Karachi face several recurring difficulties when using public transport:

- Lack of awareness of which bus route serves a given origin and destination pair.
- Uncertainty about where to switch buses (transfer points) when no single route covers the journey.
- No reliable way to estimate the fare in advance, leading to confusion or overpayment.
- No reliable way to estimate travel time, making it hard to plan around work, classes, or appointments.
- Route information is scattered across informal sources rather than centralised in one accessible system.

Current Limitations

Transport authorities also lack a consolidated analytical view of their own network. Ridership, revenue, fleet utilisation, on-time performance, and passenger feedback are either not recorded digitally or are kept in disconnected systems. Without a central database, it is difficult to answer simple management questions such as which route is busiest, which stops have the highest boardings, what the daily revenue trend is, or how reliable each service is.

Need for Automation

A centralised, database-driven system is needed to (a) store the network, fleet, and operational data in a consistent relational structure, (b) expose this data through a REST API, and (c) present it through an analytical dashboard and a route planner. Automation removes the dependence on word of mouth for passengers and gives operators data-backed insight into their network.

Expected Benefits

- Passengers receive a clear route recommendation with fare, time, number of stops, and transfers.
- Operators gain a single dashboard summarising ridership, revenue, reliability, and satisfaction.
- The relational design enforces data integrity through primary keys, foreign keys, and constraints.
- The architecture is extensible to a larger network and to live data sources in future work.

8. Proposed Solution

The proposed solution is a three-tier web application following a clean separation between data, logic, and presentation.

Layer	Technology	Responsibility
Database	PostgreSQL on Neon	Stores the network, fleet, and operational data across 21 related tables with full constraints
Backend / API	Node.js + Express	REST API for CRUD operations, analytical queries, and the route finding engine; returns JSON
Frontend	HTML, CSS, Bootstrap, JavaScript	Single-page analytical dashboard that consumes the API via fetch and renders charts
Charting	Chart.js	Bar, line, area, pie, and doughnut charts on one dashboard page
Mapping	Leaflet + OpenStreetMap	Visual rendering of the planned journey on a city map

Key Features

- Graph-based journey planning with automatic transfer detection using Dijkstra's shortest path algorithm.
- Fare and travel time estimation per journey using a documented fare-stage structure.
- An analytical dashboard with key performance indicators and multiple chart types on a single page.
- A complete REST API supporting create, read, update, and delete operations plus analytical endpoints.
- A responsive, mobile-friendly interface.

Data Coverage

The routable network covers Karachi's BRT lines (Green Line, Red Line, Orange Line), the Peoples Bus Service feeder routes (R-10, R-12), and electric bus routes (EV-1, EV-3). These routes share interchange stops such as Numaish, Tower, Gurumandir, NIPA Chowrangi, and Nagan Chowrangi, which allows the route finder to plan multi-route journeys with transfers.

10. Class Diagram

The class diagram shows the layered software architecture. Incoming HTTP requests reach the Express application, which routes them to the analytics, route finder, and CRUD routers. Each router delegates to a service class, and every service uses a shared database pool. The route finder service builds an itinerary from the route and stop domain models. On the client side, the dashboard application coordinates the charts and finder modules through a single API client.

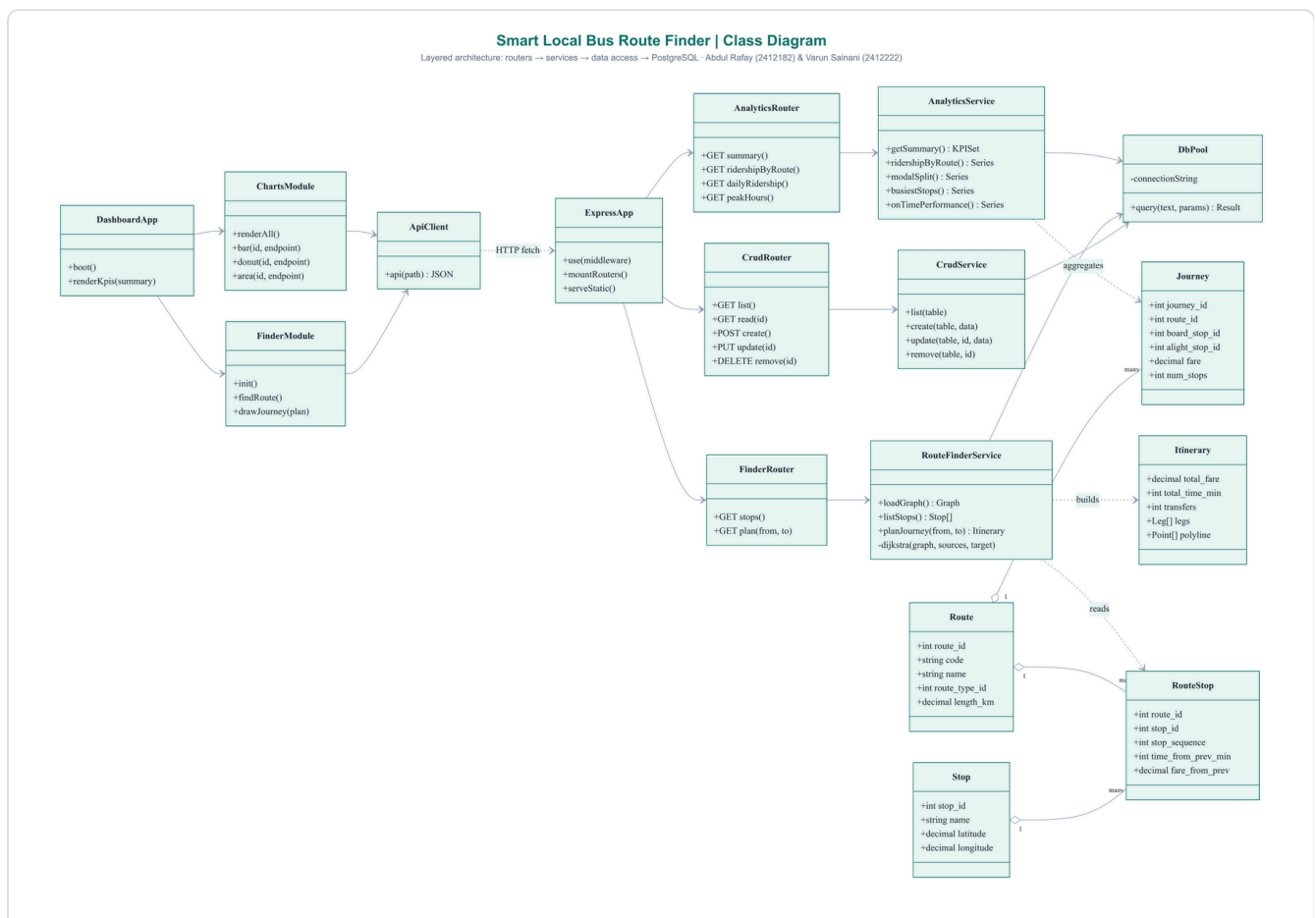


Figure 2: Class diagram showing routers, services, data access, domain models, and the frontend modules.

11. Software Specifications

Hardware Requirements

Component	Minimum Requirement
Processor	Dual core 2.0 GHz or higher
Memory (RAM)	4 GB (8 GB recommended for development)
Storage	500 MB free disk space
Network	Internet connection (the database is cloud hosted on Neon)
Client device	Any modern desktop or mobile device with a web browser

Software Requirements

Component	Requirement
Operating System	Windows, Linux, or macOS
Runtime	Node.js 18 or later
Database	PostgreSQL 16 (hosted on Neon)
Web browser	Google Chrome, Firefox, or Edge (latest)

Development Tools

Tool	Use
Visual Studio Code	Code editor
Node.js + npm	Backend runtime and package management
Express.js	REST API framework
node-postgres (pg)	PostgreSQL driver and connection pooling
Neon	Serverless PostgreSQL hosting
Bootstrap 5	Responsive UI framework
Chart.js 4	Charts and graphs
Leaflet	Interactive maps with OpenStreetMap tiles
Git and GitHub	Version control
Vercel	Deployment of the API and dashboard

12. Database Design and Implementation

The database was designed by first identifying the entities and relationships, then converting the ERD into a normalised relational schema in PostgreSQL. Every table has a primary key, foreign keys enforce referential integrity, and check constraints validate domain values (for example, ratings between 1 and 5, valid statuses, and non-negative fares). Indexes were added on the columns used by the route finder and the analytical queries.

Constraints Used

- **Primary keys** on every table (serial identity columns).
- **Foreign keys** with appropriate ON DELETE behaviour (cascade, set null, or restrict).
- **Unique constraints** (for example route code, bus registration number, card number, and the route_stop sequence).
- **Check constraints** on enumerated values, coordinate ranges, ratings, and monetary amounts.

Sample Data Volume

The database was seeded with realistic data covering the BRT and feeder network plus operational records for a thirty day window. The seed data is deterministic and reproducible.

Table	Rows	Table	Rows	Table	Rows
zone	7	bus_model	6	fare_card	365
operator	4	bus	52	card_transaction	6,320
route_type	4	driver	55	journey	6,000
route	7	staff	35	route_search	3,148
stop	49	schedule	126	feedback	850
route_stop	61	trip_log	3,780	incident	130
fare_stage	9	maintenance	160	passenger	420

Total: more than 22,000 rows across 21 tables.

Example DDL (route_stop, the graph edge table)

```
CREATE TABLE route_stop (  
  route_stop_id      SERIAL PRIMARY KEY,  
  route_id           INT NOT NULL REFERENCES route(route_id) ON DELETE CASCADE,  
  stop_id            INT NOT NULL REFERENCES stop(stop_id),  
  stop_sequence       INT NOT NULL CHECK (stop_sequence >= 1),  
  distance_from_prev_km NUMERIC(6,2) NOT NULL DEFAULT 0,  
  time_from_prev_min  INT NOT NULL DEFAULT 0,  
  fare_from_prev      NUMERIC(6,2) NOT NULL DEFAULT 0,
```

```
    UNIQUE (route_id, stop_sequence),  
    UNIQUE (route_id, stop_id)  
);
```

13. API Development

The REST API is built with Node.js and Express and connects to PostgreSQL through a pooled connection. It exposes three groups of endpoints: CRUD endpoints for the core entities, analytical endpoints that run aggregate queries, and the route finder endpoints. All responses are JSON.

API Endpoints and Methods

Method	Endpoint	Description
GET	/api/health	Service and database health check
GET	/api/analytics/summary	Key performance indicators for the dashboard
GET	/api/analytics/ridership-by-route	Journeys and revenue per route
GET	/api/analytics/modal-split	Ridership share by service type
GET	/api/analytics/daily-ridership	Daily ridership over the last 30 days
GET	/api/analytics/daily-revenue	Daily fare revenue over the last 30 days
GET	/api/analytics/peak-hours	Passenger distribution by hour of day
GET	/api/analytics/busiest-stops	Top stops by boardings
GET	/api/analytics/fleet-fuel-mix	Fleet composition by fuel type
GET	/api/analytics/payment-methods	Top ups by payment method
GET	/api/analytics/on-time-performance	On-time percentage per route
GET	/api/analytics/rating-by-route	Average passenger rating per route
GET	/api/analytics/top-od-pairs	Most searched destinations
GET	/api/analytics/incidents-by-type	Incidents grouped by type
GET	/api/finder/stops	All stops for the search pickers
GET	/api/finder/plan?from=&to=	Plan a journey (Dijkstra) with legs, fare, and time
GET	/api/{resource}	List a resource (routes, stops, passengers, drivers, etc.)
GET	/api/{resource}/:id	Read a single record
POST	/api/{resource}	Create a record
PUT	/api/{resource}/:id	Update a record
DELETE	/api/{resource}/:id	Delete a record

CRUD endpoints are provided for eight resources: routes, stops, passengers, drivers, operators, buses, feedback, and incidents.

The Route Finder Engine

The route finder loads the network as a graph where each node is a (route, stop) state. Riding moves along consecutive stops of a route, and a transfer switches routes at a shared stop with a time penalty. Dijkstra's algorithm finds the lowest total travel time, after which the fare for each leg is computed from the fare-stage table. The result is a step-by-step itinerary with the total fare, time, number of stops, and transfers.

API Testing Results

The API was tested with an in-process test harness and the browser-based testing console. All endpoint checks returned HTTP 200. A representative route plan (Gulshan-e-Johar to Sea View) correctly returned a two-leg journey: route R-10 to Tower, then a transfer to route EV-1 to Sea View, total fare PKR 100, 96 minutes, 10 stops, 1 transfer.

Test	Result
Health check and database connectivity	Passed (200)
13 analytical endpoints	Passed (200, valid JSON)
CRUD round trip (POST, GET, PUT, DELETE)	Passed (201, 200, 200, 200)
Route finder with transfer	Passed (correct legs, fare, time)
Invalid input handling (same stop, unknown id)	Passed (400 / 404 with message)

14. Screenshots of API Methods

The screenshots below were captured from the project's API testing console, which calls each endpoint over HTTP and displays the method, path, status code, response time, and JSON response.

The screenshot displays the API Testing Console for the 'Smart Local Bus Route Finder' project. The console is organized into three main sections: ANALYTICS, CRUD, and ROUTE FINDER. The ANALYTICS section is currently selected, showing a list of endpoints. The main panel displays the results of three GET requests:

- GET /api/health**: Status 200 OK, Response Time 212 ms. The response is a JSON object:

```
{  "status": "ok",  "db": "connected",  "time": "2026-06-30T17:07:44.883Z"}
```
- GET /api/analytics/summary**: Status 200 OK, Response Time 420 ms. The response is a JSON object:

```
{  "total_stops": 49,  "total_routes": 7,  "total_passengers": 420,  "total_journeys": 6000,  "network_km": 109,  "total_revenue": 193885,  "today_ridership": 167,  "avg_rating": "4.06",  "on_time_pct": "85.0",  "active_buses": 42,  "open_incidents": 29}
```
- GET /api/analytics/ridership-by-route**: Status 200 OK, Response Time 218 ms. The response is a JSON array of route objects:

```
[  {    "code": "GREEN",    "name": "Green Line BRT",    "color": "#2e7d32",    "rides": 1826,    "revenue": 36150  },  {    "code": "RED",    "name": "Red Line BRT",    "color": "#d32f2f",    "rides": 1424,    "revenue": 32700  },  {    "code": "R-10",
```

Figure 3: GET endpoints returning HTTP 200 with JSON responses and response times.

API Testing Console

Smart Local Bus Route Finder · Node.js + Express + PostgreSQL (Neon)

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ANALYTICS

- GET analytics/summary
- GET analytics/ridership-by-route
- GET analytics/modal-split
- GET analytics/daily-ridership
- GET analytics/peak-hours
- GET analytics/busiest-stops
- GET analytics/on-time-performance
- GET analytics/top-od-pairs

CRUD

- GET routes
- POST feedback
- PUT feedback/id
- DELETE feedback/id

ROUTE FINDER

- GET finder/stops
- GET finder/plan?from=18&to=43

Run all GET tests

Run CRUD round-trip (POST → GET → PUT → DELETE)

Clear

POST /api/feedback 201 OK

222 ms

```
{
  "feedback_id": 851,
  "passenger_id": 1,
  "route_id": 1,
  "journey_id": null,
  "rating": 5,
  "category": "App",
  "comment": "API test entry",
  "created_at": "2026-06-30T12:07:48.487Z"
}
```

GET /api/feedback/851 200 OK

208 ms

```
{
  "feedback_id": 851,
  "passenger_id": 1,
  "route_id": 1,
  "journey_id": null,
  "rating": 5,
  "category": "App",
  "comment": "API test entry",
  "created_at": "2026-06-30T12:07:48.487Z"
}
```

PUT /api/feedback/851 200 OK

210 ms

```
{
  "feedback_id": 851,
  "passenger_id": 1,
  "route_id": 1,
  "journey_id": null,
  "rating": 4,
  "category": "App",
  "comment": "Updated via API test",
  "created_at": "2026-06-30T12:07:48.487Z"
}
```

DELETE /api/feedback/851 200 OK

206 ms

```
{
```

Figure 4: CRUD round trip showing POST (201 Created), GET (200), PUT (200), and DELETE (200).

15. JavaScript Code Showing API Calls

The dashboard consumes the API using the browser fetch API. A single helper wraps every request, and the chart and finder modules call it.

api.js - the fetch helper

```
// Thin fetch (AJAX) wrapper used by the whole dashboard.
async function api(path) {
  const res = await fetch(window.API_BASE + path);
  if (!res.ok) {
    let msg = res.status;
    try { msg = (await res.json()).error || msg; } catch (e) {}
    throw new Error(path + " -> " + msg);
  }
  return res.json();
}
```

charts.js - calling an analytical endpoint and drawing a chart

```
async function bar(id, path, opts) {
  const rows = await api(path); // AJAX call to the REST API
  new Chart(document.getElementById(id), {
    type: "bar",
    data: {
      labels: rows.map(r => r[opts.labelKey]),
      datasets: [{ data: rows.map(r => Number(r[opts.valueKey])) }]
    }
  });
}
bar("ridershipChart", "/api/analytics/ridership-by-route", { labelKey: "code", valueKey: "rides" });
```

finder.js - requesting a journey plan

```
async function findRoute() {
  const from = document.getElementById("fromStop").value;
  const to = document.getElementById("toStop").value;
  const plan = await api(`/api/finder/plan?from=${from}&to=${to}`);
  renderPlan(plan); // draw the itinerary and the map polyline
}
```

16. Dashboard Design and Implementation

The dashboard is a single page built with HTML, CSS, Bootstrap, and JavaScript. On load it calls the summary endpoint to populate the key performance indicator cards, then renders every chart by fetching its analytical endpoint, and finally initialises the route finder with the live map.

Key Performance Indicators

Eight cards summarise the network: active routes, network stops, network length, registered riders, journeys in the last thirty days, fare revenue, average rating, and on-time performance.

Charts on a Single Page

The dashboard presents all visualisations on one page using Chart.js, covering every required chart type:

Chart type	Visualisation
Bar	Ridership by route, on-time performance, average rating, incidents by type
Horizontal bar	Busiest stops, most searched destinations
Line	Daily ridership trend
Area	Daily fare revenue, passengers by hour of day
Doughnut	Ridership by service type, top ups by payment method
Pie	Fleet by fuel type

Route Finder and Map

The route finder lets the user pick an origin and destination, then displays the planned journey as a set of legs with fare and time, and draws each leg on a Leaflet map using the route's colour. Transfers are highlighted between legs.

17. Final Output Screenshots

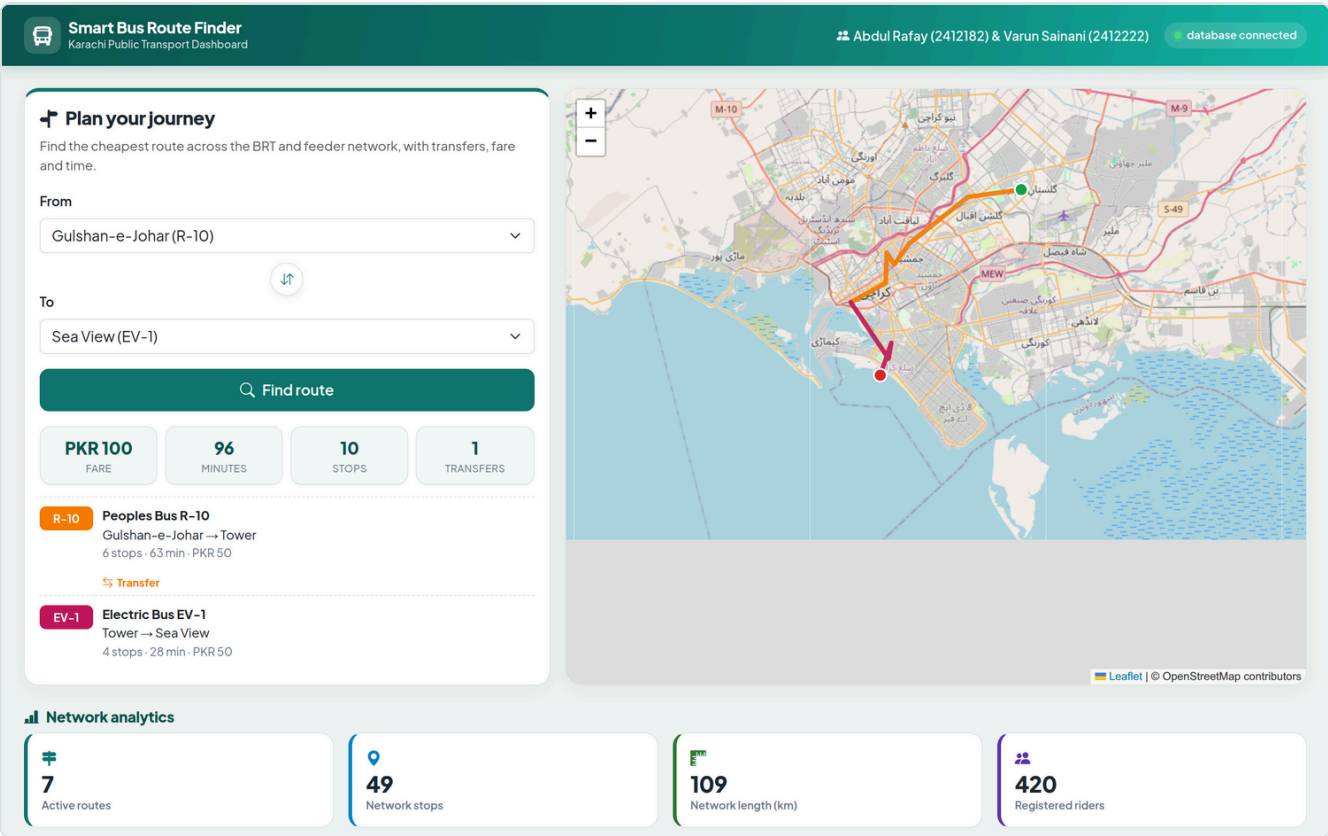


Figure 5: Dashboard with the route finder, live map, and key performance indicator cards.

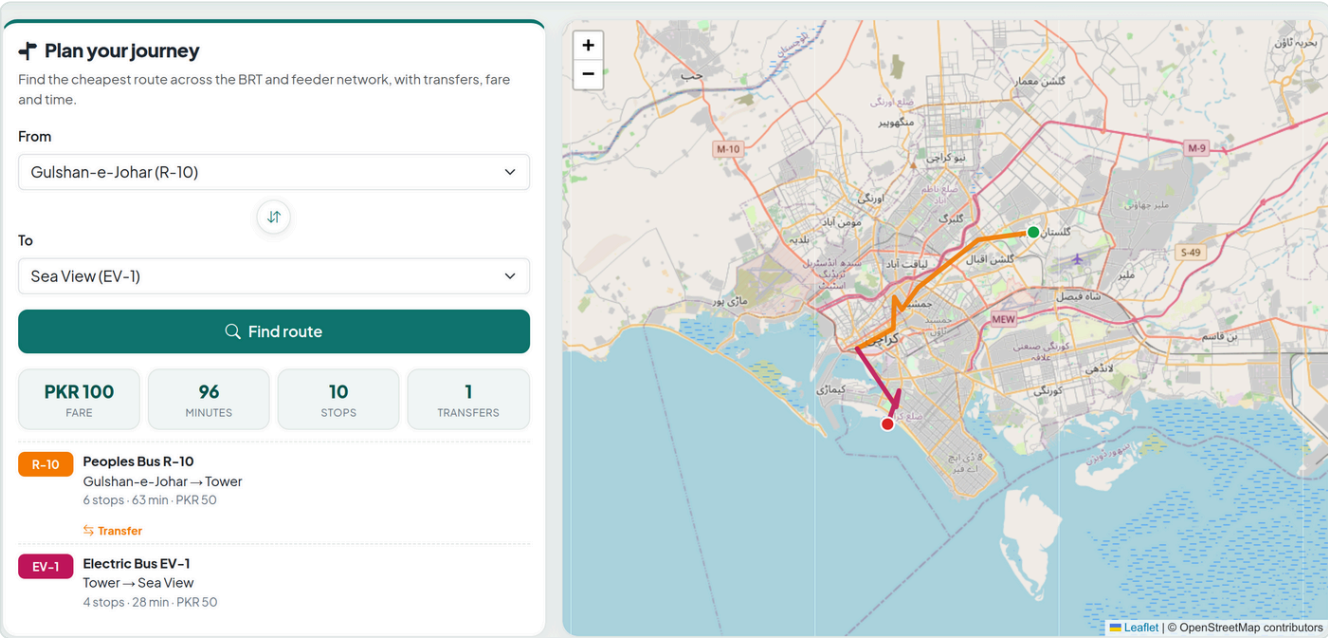


Figure 7: A planned journey with a transfer, fare, time, and stops drawn on the map.



Figure 6: The full analytical dashboard showing all charts on a single page.

18. Conclusion

The Smart Local Bus Route Finder demonstrates a complete database-driven analytical dashboard built to the project guidelines. A normalised PostgreSQL database of 21 tables, hosted on Neon, stores the network, fleet, and operational data with full primary keys, foreign keys, and constraints. A Node.js and Express REST API exposes CRUD and analytical endpoints that return JSON, and a single-page dashboard built with HTML, CSS, Bootstrap, and JavaScript consumes this API to present meaningful insights through bar, line, area, pie, and doughnut charts.

Beyond the analytical dashboard, the project implements a practical route finding engine using Dijkstra's shortest path algorithm over the bus stop graph, with automatic transfer detection, fare estimation, and travel time estimation, visualised on an interactive map. The system was tested end to end, with all API endpoints returning correct responses and the route finder producing accurate multi-route journeys.

The project meets every submission requirement: a relational schema of more than sixteen tables, a working REST API, and an analytical dashboard presenting insights generated from the database. The architecture is modular and can be extended to a larger network, additional analytics, and live data sources in future work.

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